John’s Gospel

BISA Course: Johannine Writings

1st Semester 2019

(Source: *Four Portraits, One Jesus* - M. Strauss)

John’s Gospel

» chapter overview «

- Literary Features
- The Plot of John’s Gospel
- John’s Portrait of Jesus: The Son Who Reveals the Father
- Other Characters in John’s Gospel
- Theological Themes
- Narrative Purpose
- The Historical Setting of John’s Gospel: Author and Life Setting
- Reading John Today

John’s Gospel

» literary features«

Unique Content

- The reader approaching John’s Gospel immediately notices a picture strikingly different from the Synoptic Gospels. While the Synoptics share many common features, about 90 percent of John is unique. Key features of Jesus’ ministry are absent. There are no exorcisms or parables (but see 12:24: a kernel of wheat), no table fellowship with sinners. The key Synoptic phrase “kingdom of God” occurs only twice. Most of Jesus’ teaching is unique, and five of John’s eight miracles do not occur in the Synoptics. Many key Synoptic events are absent, including Jesus’ baptism, his temptation, the transfiguration, and the institution of the Lord’s Supper.
- John also includes many stories not found in the Synoptics: the miracle of changing water to wine, Jesus’ conversations with Nicodemus and the Samaritan woman, the raising of Lazarus, Jesus’ washing of the disciple’s feet, Jesus’ high priestly prayer, the account of doubting Thomas, and many others.

John’s Gospel

» central theme «

- Jesus is the divine Son of God who reveals the Father, providing eternal life to all who believe in him.

» key verse «

- John 3:16 (cf. 1:14; 20:30–31)

» basic outline of john «

- Prologue (1:1–18)
- The Book of Signs (1:19–12:50)
- The Book of Glory (13:1–20:31)
- Epilogue (21:1–25)

John’s Gospel

» characteristics of john’s gospel «

Look for these while reading John’s Gospel:

- Emphasis on Jesus’ identity as the Son who reveals the Father.
- Simple vocabulary, but deep theological significance (‘*a child can wade…*’)
- Key thematic terms: life, believe, abide, light.
- Strong dualistic perspective: people are either “of God” or “of the world.”
- Miracles identified as “signs” revealing Jesus’ identity.
- Spiritual symbols and metaphors: water, light, bread, shepherd, gate.
- Jesus’ “I am” statements.

John’s Gospel

» characteristics of john’s gospel « *(continued)*

- The motif of misunderstanding; people misconstrue Jesus’ words.
- Irony, especially concerning misperceptions of Jesus.
- Personal interviews (Nicodemus; the Samaritan woman).
- Dialogues and debates between Jesus and the religious leaders.
- Chronology based on Jewish festivals, especially Passover.
- The “disciple whom Jesus loved,” a key but enigmatic character.
- Clear statement of purpose: a call to faith in Jesus, the Son of God.
- Teachings concerning the Holy Spirit as counsellor or advocate (*paraclete)* who will mediate Jesus’ presence.

John's Gospel

Dialogues with Jesus in John's Gospel

- Jesus and his first disciples (1:35–51; 4:27, 31–38; 9:1–7; 11:1–16; 14:1–31; 16:17–33)
- Jesus and Nicodemus (a leader among the Jews, 3:1–21)
- Jesus and the Samaritan woman (an apostle to the Samaritans, 4:1–42)
- Jesus and the royal official (4:46–54)
- Jesus and the invalid (5:5–15)
- Jesus and the religious leaders in Jerusalem I (5:16–47; 7:14–8:59)
- Jesus and the crowd, the Jewish leaders, the disciples and Peter (6:25–70)
- Jesus and the seeing blind man (9:35–41)

John's Gospel

Dialogues with Jesus in John's Gospel (continued…)

- Jesus and the sisters of Lazarus (11:17–45)
- Jesus and the Greeks and the Jerusalem crowd (12:20–36)
- Jesus and Peter (13:1–20; 21:15–23)
- Jesus and the high priest and the guard (18:19–24)
- Jesus and Pilate (18:28–19:16)
- Jesus and Mary Magdalene (20:11–18)
- Jesus and Thomas (20:24–29)

(Anderson)

John's Gospel

» characteristics of john's gospel « *(continued)*

- Only John reports Jesus' extensive Judean ministry, as he travels back and forth between Galilee and Judea. The Synoptics are more linear, with a single movement from Galilee to Jerusalem. They provide little information concerning the length of Jesus' ministry, mentioning only the Passover associated with Jesus' crucifixion. John refers to three Passovers (2:13; 6:4; 11:55) and possibly a fourth (5:1), suggesting a ministry between 2½ and 3½ years long.
- Jesus also speaks more openly about himself in John than in the other Gospels. In the Synoptics, Jesus' teaching focuses on the kingdom of God and his role as its inaugurator. In John, he speaks much more about himself and his unique relationship to the Father. Jesus makes seven **"I am" statements — metaphorical descriptions of himself and his role as the Son who reveals the Father. There is no "messianic secret" in John.**

John's Gospel

» characteristics of john's gospel « *(continued)*

- John's literary style is also unique. It is characterized by simplicity, with short sentences connected by coordinate conjunctions ("and"). The style is repetitious, with parallelism used for emphasis (e.g., John 14:27: "Peace I leave with you; my peace I give you.").
- There are also many contrasts: light and darkness, truth and falsehood, life and death, above and below. While John's vocabulary is basic, seemingly "simple" words like *know, abide, believe, witness, truth, life, light, glory,* and *the world* carry profound theological significance.
- This unique style is evident in Jesus' words. Jesus speaks not in parables and short wisdom sayings, as in the Synoptics, but in long discourses and dialogues with his opponents.

John's Gospel

» characteristics of john's gospel « *(continued)*

- Jesus' style of speaking so resembles the narrator's that sometimes it is difficult to tell when Jesus stops speaking and the narrator starts. For example, in Jesus' dialogue with Nicodemus in John 3, most "red letter" Bibles continue Jesus' words through verse 21. But it is not clear in the text whether he is still speaking.
- This raises the difficult issue of how much this Gospel records the actual words of Jesus, and how much of it is the author's interpretation of Jesus' life and teaching. This question does not challenge the authority of the text, since inspiration applies to everything the author wrote—speech, actions, narration, interpretation. But it does affect how we view the literary genre of the Fourth Gospel. Is this Gospel meant to be a historical record of Jesus' life, or a theological meditation on its significance? Or both?

John’s Gospel

» historicity of john’s gospel «

- Though the reliability of John’s Gospel has been questioned even more than the Synoptics, recent research has produced greater respect for its historicity.
- Jesus’ unique style of speaking in John is not as different from the Synoptics as is sometimes supposed and may be explained by a combination of John’s paraphrase of Jesus’ teaching and his Spirit-inspired interpretation of Jesus’ words.
- John’s high Christology is not as unique as is sometimes supposed. The Synoptics also reveal an implicit high Christology, while John shares with them an emphasis on Jesus’ messiahship and the mystery which surrounds his identity.
- It is a false dichotomy to contrast the historical and theological features of the Gospels. Good history can also be good theology. (Strauss)

John’s Gospel

» historicity of john’s gospel « (Blomberg)

- Features of John’s Gospel that actually make it more like Greco-Roman historiography of the day than the Synoptics - notably greater number of references to geography and topography, chronology & reliance on eyewitnesses.
- There are misunderstandings recorded in the Gospel (cf. the destruction of the temple in Jn.2) that demonstrate that John remained faithful to the (mis)understanding(s) held by Jesus’ audiences during his earthly ministry.
- Many of the details in John accurately fit pre-70 Judaism better than post-70 states of affairs and are therefore not likely to have been made up at the end of the first century with no factual basis. With the destruction of the temple, all of the festival celebrations in Jerusalem that John stresses would have no longer been possible.

John’s Gospel

» historicity of john’s gospel « (Blomberg)

- John’s Gospel actually contains more details of time and place in the course of Jesus’ ministry than do the Synoptics. It is only from John that we are able to determine that Jesus’ ministry spanned approximately a three-year period. It is only John who preserves a careful chronological sequence of virtually all the details he narrates. Several studies have demonstrated how John’s references to geography and topography prove remarkably accurate, particularly in and around Jerusalem (e.g. pools of Bethesda & Siloam).
- Finally, in light of the central role of such themes as “witness” and “truth” (cf., e.g., 1:7–8, 19; 2:25; 3:11, 32–33; 5:31–40; 8:13–18; 15:26; 19:35, 21:24), it is difficult to imagine John dealing so creatively with the traditions he inherited as to actually distort them in ways that were truly unfaithful to the spirit of Jesus.

John's Gospel

The Relationship of John to the Synoptics

- The many differences between John and the Synoptics also raise the question of their literary relationship. Did the author of the Fourth Gospel know and use the Synoptics, or is he writing independently of them? Until the twentieth century, it was generally believed that John wrote to supplement and interpret the other Gospels. The tide turned in the mid-twentieth century when P. Gardner-Smith and others argued for John's literary independence. The stories which John and the Synoptics share come not from direct borrowing, it was argued, but from the use of common traditions. Today scholars are divided.
- A mediating position denies direct borrowing but thinks John may know one or more of the Synoptics and assumes his readers will be familiar with their content. This third perspective is perhaps the most appealing, since it recognizes both John's dependence and independence. He is interacting within the world of early Christianity, yet writes to accomplish his own unique purpose.

John's Gospel

Two Historical Settings, Two Levels of Meaning

- Narrative always has two historical settings, the setting of the events portrayed and the later setting of the author. The events of the Gospels occurred during Jesus' ministry in Palestine about AD 30. But the Gospels themselves were written much later.
- The Gospel of John is unique in that the boundary between its two settings is often blurred. At times the narrator seems to be speaking not only of the conflict between Jesus and his opponents but also of the late-first-century conflict between the author's Christian community and its Jewish opponents.
- This blurring is evident in many ways but is most striking in the author's frequent use of the term *Ioudaioi* ("Jews" or "Jewish leaders") for Jesus' opponents. This is odd, since Jesus and his disciples were also Jews. Historically, the conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders was *Jew versus Jew*. The author's use of this term for Jesus' opponents suggests that the conflict is now Christian versus Jew and that he is writing at a time when the church has broken with the synagogue. Scholars find further evidence for this break in John's repeated references to expulsion from the synagogue (9:22; 12:42; 16:2). The possibility of two settings and two levels of meaning should be kept in mind when reading John.

John's Gospel

Structure

- The Gospel has a relatively simple structure. It begins with a **prologue (1:1-18) identifying Jesus as the pre-existent "Word" (*Logos)* — God's self-revelation—who became a human being to bring grace and truth to humankind. It ends with an epilogue (chap. 21) describing a post-resurrection appearance to the disciples, Jesus' commissioning of Peter to "feed my sheep," and the identification of the Beloved Disciple as the author.**
- **The main body of the Gospel has two parts, sometimes called the *Book of Signs* (1:19-12:50) and the *Book of Glory* (13:1-20:31). The former contains seven miracles, or "signs," which reveal Jesus' identity and call people to faith in him. The Book of Glory is so called because Jesus' passion is repeatedly described as his glorification (7:39; 12:23; 13:31-32; 17:1, 4; cf. 21:19). This section contains the Last Supper, the Farewell Discourse, and the passion and resurrection narratives.**

Teaching Types:

Personal Interviews, Public Debate, and Private Teaching

Parallels in John 3 and 4	
Nicodemus *John 3*	**The Samaritan Woman** *John 4*
(1) Jesus sparks interest with a spiritual metaphor: new birth (3:3).	(1) Jesus sparks interest with a spiritual metaphor: living water (4:10).
(2) Nicodemus is confused (3:4).	(2) The woman is confused (4:11–12).
(3) Jesus clarifies the spiritual significance (3:5).	(3) Jesus clarifies the spiritual significance (4:13, 21–24).
(4) More confusion by Nicodemus (3:9).	(4) More confusion by the woman (4:15).
(5) More clarification and a mild rebuke from Jesus (3:10–12).	(5) More clarification and a mild rebuke from Jesus (4:21–24).
(6) Jesus identifies himself as the Son of Man, the Son of God, and the light (3:13–21).	(6) Jesus identifies himself as the Messiah (v. 26).
(7) No response recorded.	(7) The woman reports to the town; many Samaritans believe.

John's Gospel

Figure 10.1—The Seven "Signs" (*sēmeia*) of John's Gospel

1. Changing water into wine (2:1–11)
2. Official's son healed (4:43–54)
3. Healing of the disabled man at Bethesda pool (5:1–15)
4. Feeding of the five thousand (6:1–14)
5. Walking on water (6:16–21)
6. Healing the man born blind (9:1–12)
7. Lazarus raised (11:1–44)

Epilogue sign: the miraculous catch of fish (21:1–14)

John's Gospel

The "Signs" of the Gospel

- While the Gospel records only eight miracles, these **"signs" (*sēmeia*) play a key role in Jesus' self-revelation.** **Seven appear in the Gospel proper, and one (the miraculous catch of fish) in the epilogue. The signs are often interpreted by Jesus' teaching. Jesus feeds the five thousand and then gives a discourse on the bread of life (chap. 6). Similarly, he raises Lazarus from the dead after identifying himself as the resurrection and the life (11:25–26).**
- Each sign reveals Jesus' identity and mission and calls forth a decision from the hearers. After the first sign, changing water to wine at the wedding in Cana, the narrator notes that "this, the first of his miraculous signs, Jesus performed at Cana in Galilee. He thus revealed his glory, and his disciples put their faith in him" (2:11). The sign reveals Jesus' glory, which provokes faith in him as the self-revelation of God. This is somewhat different from the Synoptic miracles, which point to the in-breaking of the kingdom of God and Jesus' authority as its inaugurator (Matt. 12:28; Luke 11:20).

John's Gospel

Metaphor and Symbol

- John's "spiritual" Gospel often operates at the level of metaphor and symbol. Jesus is identified at the outset as the "Word," a metaphor for God's communicative presence. John the Baptist calls him the "Lamb of God," a symbol for sacrificial death (1:29). The seven "I am" statements are also metaphorical. Jesus is the bread of life, the light of the world, the door, the good shepherd, the resurrection and the life, the one true path to life, and the true vine. Like so much else in this Gospel, simple and everyday images reveal profound theological truth.
- For those without faith, however, the symbols mask the truth, creating confusion and misunderstanding. Nicodemus cannot comprehend the metaphor of new birth. The woman at the well is at first confused by Jesus' reference to living water. His Jewish opponents are baffled when Jesus—referring to his own body—says, "Destroy this temple, and I will raise it again in three days" (2:19). Like the Synoptic parables, the metaphors and symbols of the Fourth Gospel both reveal and conceal.

John's Gospel

Figure 10.3—Seven "I Am" Statements of John's Gospel
1. The Bread of Life (6:35)
2. The Light of the World (8:12; 9:5)
3. The Door (10:7)
4. The Good Shepherd (10:11, 14)
5. The Resurrection and the Life (11:25)
6. The Way, the Truth, and the Life (14:6)
7. The True Vine (15:1)

John's Gospel

Irony

- Since misunderstanding is a common theme in John, irony plays a major role as characters deny or question things that, ironically, are true. Nathanael asks if anything good can come from Nazareth (1:46). The Samaritan woman asks sarcastically, "Are you greater than our father Jacob?" (4:12).
- Irony also appears in double meanings given to words. Jesus tells Nicodemus that he must be "born again." The Greek *anōthen* can mean either "again" or "from above." While Nicodemus misunderstands this as physical rebirth, Jesus means spiritual or heavenly birth through the Spirit. Jesus offers the Samaritan woman "living water" (4:10). She misunderstands "living" to mean bubbling spring water, but Jesus means spiritual water which gives eternal life (4:13–14).
- In a greater sense, the whole Gospel is ironic, since God's great salvation is accomplished through the death of his Son. In a play on words, Jesus repeatedly refers to his crucifixion as a "lifting up" (3:14; 8:28; 12:32–34). The physical lifting of the cross—a symbol of horrific death—points to Jesus' glorious victory and exaltation following his resurrection.

John's Gospel

Figure 10.4—The Chiastic Structure of John's Prologue *God's Self-Revelation through the Logos*
A. The Identity and Mission of the Word (vv. 1–5)
B. The Testimony of John the Baptist to the Word (vv. 6–8)
C. The Incarnation of the Word (vv. 9–10a)
D. Response to the Word (vv. 10–13)
C′. The Incarnation of the Word (v. 14)
B′. The Testimony of John the Baptist to the Word (v. 15)
A′. The Identity and Mission of the Word (vv. 16–18)

John's Gospel

- The prologue is the most profound statement of Jesus' identity (Christology) in the New Testament, identifying Jesus as the "Word" (Logos), the pre-existent creator of the universe, distinct from the Father yet fully divine.
- The term Logos had a conceptual background both in Judaism and in Greek philosophical thought. In the Old Testament, God's word is the dynamic force of his will. The psalmist declares, "By the word [LXX: logos] of the LORD were the heavens made" (Ps. 33:6). God speaks, and it is done (Isa. 55:11). In Greek philosophy, logos was used of the divine reason which brought unity and order to the cosmos. Jewish and Greek ideas come together in the Hellenistic Jewish philosopher Philo, who identified the Logos as the messenger of God, mediator between God and creation.
- The author of the prologue probably chose the term because of its rich conceptual background, drawing from both its Greek and Jewish background. Yet in the prologue itself, he gave the term new and deeper theological significance by applying it to the profound mystery of the incarnation of the Son of God.

John's Gospel

The Plot

- The prologue (chap. 1) describes Jesus as the incarnate Word (*Logos) of God, the one and only Son who reveals the Father & brings life & light to humanity.*
- As in the Synoptics, John the Baptist is the forerunner who prepares the way for Jesus the Messiah. John identifies Jesus as the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world.
- Jesus' first miracle at Cana in Galilee (chap. 2) reveals his glory, and his disciples believe in him. The wedding miracle is symbolic of the messianic banquet, a picture of God's final salvation.
- Jesus' clearing of the temple symbolically indicates the end of the sacrificial system and the coming of salvation through the destruction of the new "temple" (Jesus' body).
- Nicodemus (chap. 3) represents the spiritual blindness of Israel's religious leaders, who fail to comprehend the spiritual reality of new birth through the Spirit.

John's Gospel

Figure 10.6—Dualism in John's Gospel	
Children of Light	**Children of Darkness**
Believe on the Son.	Reject the Son.
Walk in the light.	Walk in darkness.
Live by the truth.	Follow the lie.
Have eternal life now.	Are condemned already.
Will never perish.	Abide in God's wrath.
Are from above.	Are from the earth.

John's Gospel

The Plot

- The account of the Samaritan woman (chap. 4) demonstrates that Jesus is the promised Messiah who brings living water (eternal life) to all who believe.
- Jesus' healing of the lame man at the Pool of Bethesda (chap. 5) is the beginning of the back-and-forth debate between Jesus and the religious leaders in the context of the Jewish festivals. By healing on the Sabbath, Jesus identifies himself with the Father, who works even on the Sabbath to sustain the universe.
- The feeding of the five thousand (chap. 6) is the only miracle to appear in all four Gospels. Jesus is the bread of life who provides true spiritual manna, recalling the Passover festival.
- Though many disciples desert Jesus, Peter (representing the Twelve) confesses that he is the Holy One of God who brings words of eternal life (6:68).

John's Gospel

p 314 Figure 10.8—Jesus and the Fulfillment of the Jewish Festivals	
Sabbath	John 5
Passover	John 6
Tabernacles	John 7–8
Hanukkah	John 10

John's Gospel

The Plot

- In his teaching at the Feast of Tabernacles (chaps. 7–8), Jesus draws on festival symbols to identify himself as living water and the light of the world. He also identifies himself as the "I am"—the divine name of God from Exodus 3:14.
- The healing of the man born blind (chap. 9) contrasts the spiritual blindness of Israel's leaders with the spiritual insight of those who believe in Jesus.
- Recalling the Hanukkah festival, Jesus contrasts himself as the good shepherd with the religious leaders, who are thieves or mere hired hands (chap. 10).
- The raising of Lazarus (chap. 11), the greatest of the seven "signs," reveals Jesus' authority as bringer of resurrection life and provokes the religious leaders to act against him.
- As in the Synoptics, Jesus' triumphal entry serves as a public announcement of his messiahship (chap. 12).

John's Gospel

Figure 10.10—The Woman Caught in Adultery (John 7:53–8:11)
An Authentic Tradition?

The story of the woman caught in adultery, which appears in our Bible at John 7:53–8:11, does not seem to have been an original part of John's Gospel. Its style and vocabulary are unlike the rest of the Gospel, it breaks the flow of the narrative, and it does not appear in the oldest and most reliable manuscripts. In some others, it appears at a different place (after John 7:36; 7:44; or 21:25) and even in a different Gospel (after Luke 21:38).

What can we say about the story? While probably not an original part of John, the story has the ring of authenticity and sounds very much like what we know of the historical Jesus. Many scholars consider it to be an authentic historical episode, a "floating tradition" which was passed down by word of mouth and eventually found its way into different places in the New Testament.

John's Gospel

The Plot

- The Book of Glory (chaps. 13–20) begins with the Last Supper narrative. Jesus washes the disciples feet, teaches on servanthood and love (chap. 13), and gives his Farewell Discourse (chaps. 14–16). He promises to send the Spirit as teacher, comforter, and guide during his absence. The disciples are called to "abide" in him.
- In his "high-priestly prayer" (chap. 17), Jesus asks the Father for protection and unity for his disciples.
- The main theme of the trial and crucifixion in John is that Jesus is in control of his destiny and is acting according to God's plan (chaps. 18–19).
- John's resurrection narrative is unique in Jesus' appearance to Mary Magdalene alone and in appearances to the disciples first without, and then with, Thomas present (chap. 20). Thomas's confession, "My Lord and my God!" frames (an *inclusio) the entire Gospel between two acclamations of Jesus' deity (1:1; 20:28)*.
- The epilogue (chap. 21) includes the miraculous catch of fish, the restoration and commissioning of Peter, and the role of the Beloved Disciple in the composition of the Gospel.

John's Gospel

The Myths about Mary Magdalene

- Who was Mary Magdalene? We can actually say more about who she was not. She was not a prostitute and she did not anoint Jesus' feet and wipe them with her tears. The myth about Mary as a prostitute arose because of confusion in the church between various women: Mary Magdalene, Mary of Bethany (Luke 10, John 11), the sinful woman who anointed Jesus' feet in Luke 7:36–50, and the woman caught in adultery (John 7:53–8:11). In the late sixth century, Pope Gregory the Great delivered a homily in which he pronounced all of these different women to be one and the same. The confusion has persisted ever since. From the Gospels, all we know about Mary are four facts:
- She was one of the women disciples who supported Jesus financially (Luke 8:2–3).
- She had seven demons cast out of her (Luke 8:2).
- She was with other women at the crucifixion (Mark 15:40; Matt. 27:56; John 19:25), at the burial (Mark 16:1; Matt. 27:61), and at the empty tomb (Mark 15:47; Matt. 28:1; Luke 24:10).
- According to John, Mary went to the tomb alone and was the first witness to the resurrected Jesus (John 20:1–2, 10–18).

John’s Gospel

John’s Portrait of Jesus: The Son Who Reveals the Father

- Jesus’ identity is on centre stage throughout the Fourth Gospel, which presents the most exalted Christology in the New Testament.
- Jesus is the unique Son of God who has come from the Father. He is God’s Word (Logos), his self-revelation (1:1, 14, 18). Whoever has seen him has seen the Father (14:9). While distinct from the Father (“with God,” 1:1), he is fully God (“was God,” 1:1; 20:28), the I AM” who existed before Abraham (8:24, 28, 58).

John’s Gospel

John’s Portrait of Jesus: The Son Who Reveals the Father

- He shares God’s attributes. He is the creator of all things (1:3, 10), the giver and sustainer of life (5:16–18, 26; 6:27, 35, 50–58), who will raise the dead (5:21, 25; 4:53; 6:39–40, 44, 54; 10:28; 11:25–26) and serve as final judge (5:22, 27).
- He is omniscient (1:48; 2:24–25; 6:15; 8:14; 13:1, 11; 21:17). As the Son sent from above, he provides the only access to the Father and to eternal life: “No one comes to the Father except through me” (14:6; cf. 3:16, 36; 4:14; 5:21–26; 6:33, 35, 51–58, 68; 8:12; 10:10, 17–18; 11:25; 17:2–3). The Father and Son operate in complete unity (10:30; 14:10) and know one another perfectly (10:15).

John’s Gospel

The Disciples

- The two most prominent disciples are Peter and the enigmatic Beloved Disciple.
- As in the Synoptics, Peter is bold yet erratic. He confidently confesses his faith in Jesus (6:69) and in loyalty lashes out against Jesus’ enemies (18:10). Yet a few verses later, he denies he even knows Jesus (18:15–18, 25–27). With Peter’s three confessions, he is finally ready to assume the roles of a shepherd over Jesus’ flock and a martyr for his Lord (21:15–19).

John’s Gospel

The Disciples

- From a narrative perspective, the Beloved Disciple represents the model disciple, a faithful and informed follower of Jesus. First appearing at the Last Supper, he is a close confidant of Jesus, sitting at the privileged position by his side (13:23–25). He follows Jesus after his arrest and provides Peter access to the high priest’s courtyard (18:15–16). He is present at the crucifixion, and Jesus places Mary in his care (19:26–27), indicating a relationship closer even than physical family. He outruns Peter to the tomb of Jesus and is the first to believe in the resurrection (20:4). In Galilee, he is the first to recognize the resurrected Lord on the lakeshore (21:7). Finally, he is identified as the reliable source for the Gospel, providing faithful testimony to Jesus’ ministry (21:24). All true disciples—those whom Jesus loves—should aspire to this kind of faith and devotion.

John's Gospel

The Antagonists: The Religious Leaders, "the World," & Satan

- Jesus' primary opponents are the religious leaders (*Ioudaioi*), the world, and Satan. The connections between the religious leaders, the world, and Satan reflect John's dualistic perspective.
- By opposing Jesus, these leaders have allied themselves with the evil world system (1:10; 7:7; 14:17, 22) and with Satan, "the prince of this world" (12:31; 14:30; 16:11). The "world" (*kosmos*), like *Ioudaioi*, can be used neutrally of the place where people dwell (1:10; 9:39; 13:1; 16:21, 28; 17:5, 24; 18:37) or the people whom God sent Jesus to save (1:10; 3:16, 17; 4:42; 6:33, 51; 8:12; 9:5; 17:21). More often, it carries connotations of the evil world system ruled by Satan (1:10; 7:7; 12:31; 14:17, 22, 30; 15:18–19; 16:8, 11, 20, 33; 17:16). Like the religious leaders, the world does not know Jesus (1:10; 17:25) and so hates him (7:7; 15:18) and his followers (17:14).

John's Gospel

Theological Themes

- The central theme of John's Gospel is the revelation of the Father through the Son. God loved the world so much that he sent his Son to save it, so that those who believe in him gain eternal life (Jn.3:16).
- Salvation in John is identified especially as eternal life, which is defined both as a present possession and a future inheritance (Jn.5:24).
- Salvation is a present possession because eternal life is equivalent to knowing God, a relationship with the Father through the Son (17:3). This relationship with God happens through regeneration, being "born again" (3:3), when the Father and the Son come to live in the believer (14:23). When this happens, they come to know the truth and are set free (8:32, 36). They now walk in the "light" (3:21; 8:12; 12:36, 46).

John’s Gospel

Theological Themes

- Since the Son brings life and light, how will the disciples manage after he leaves? The answer is that he will send another “counselor” or “advocate” (*paraklētos*), the Holy Spirit who will mediate his presence to them (14:16–26; 15:26–27; 16:7–15).
- It is in fact better that he is leaving, since the indwelling presence of the Father and the Son will enable them to do even greater works than his (14:12; 16:7). The Holy Spirit will guide them into all the truth, testifying about Jesus and reminding them of all Jesus taught them (14:26; 15:26)

John’s Gospel

Narrative Purpose

- The Fourth Gospel states its purpose clearly: “Jesus did many other miraculous signs in the presence of his disciples, which are not recorded in this book. But these are written that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name” (20:30–31).
- The author writes to call forth faith in Jesus. While this suggests an evangelistic purpose, the Gospel seems intended to bring confidence for believers as well. The reading “that you might believe” (*hina pisteusēte*, an aorist subjunctive) is disputed, and some early manuscripts could be translated “that you might continue to believe” (*hina pisteuēte*, a present subjunctive). These two purposes—to provoke belief and perseverance—are not mutually exclusive, and both are probably aspects of the author’s purpose. The bottom line is that John’s Gospel is a call to decision. Readers are not only introduced to the story of Jesus Christ, the Son of God; they are called to respond in faith to him.

John's Gospel

Authorship

- Like the Synoptics, the Fourth Gospel does not name its author. It comes close, however, by identifying the author with "the disciple whom Jesus loved": "This is the disciple who testifies to these things and who wrote them down. We know that his testimony is true" (21:24).
- Traditionally, the Beloved Disciple has been identified as the apostle John. This identification finds support in the narrative itself. The Beloved Disciple appears as a close associate of Peter (13:24; 20:2–10; 21:2, 7, 20–24), suggesting he was one of the "inner circle" of disciples (Peter, James [martyred early], and John). Further evidence for this identification is that John is never mentioned by name in the book. This is an unusual omission for so prominent a disciple, unless he is indeed "the disciple whom Jesus loved."

John's Gospel

Place, Occasion, and Date

- Since the eighteenth century, it was common among critical scholars to date the Fourth Gospel to the late second century, assuming its exalted view of Jesus was a late development in the church. The discovery of the John Rylands manuscript (p52), a small fragment of John dated to the first half of the second century, has refuted this claim, and most scholars today date the Gospel to the late first century.

John’s Gospel

Place, Occasion, and Date

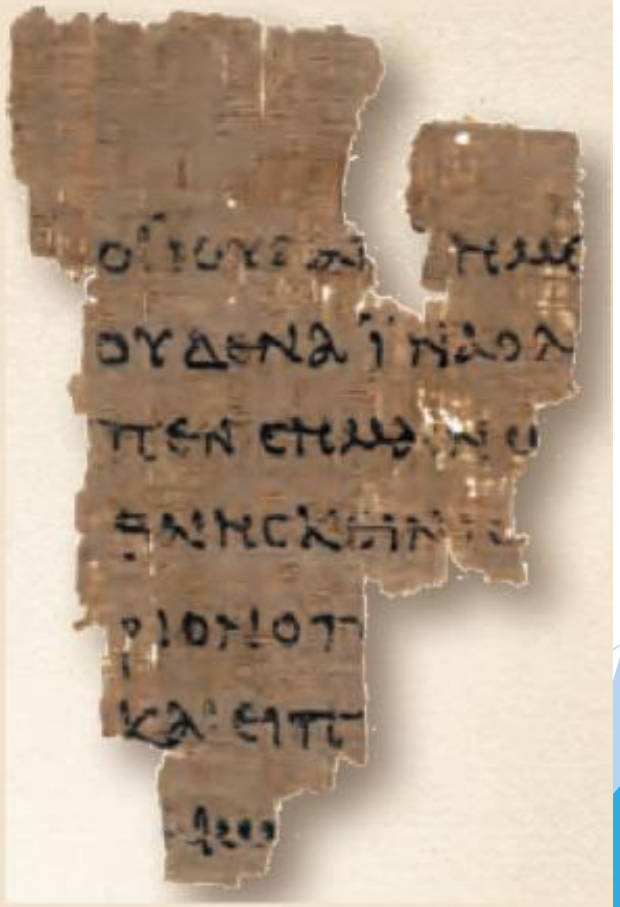
- Church tradition claims that the apostle John ministered in Ephesus in the latter part of the first century and that it was there he wrote the Gospel. Ephesus was a major crossroads of the Roman world and had a large Jewish population. In the late first century, Christians had broken with the Jewish synagogue and were increasingly viewed with suspicion by the secular authorities. This alienation would account for the Gospel’s strong polemic against both the “Jews” and the “world. John writes both to encourage believers to remain faithful to the Son and to call unbelievers to faith in him. He may also be addressing the docetic heresy.

John's Gospel

p 335 **Figure 10.12—Papyrus Manuscript P^{52}**

The Oldest New Testament Manuscript

In the past century, it was common for scholars to date the Gospel of John as late as the midsecond century AD. The discovery of the John Rylands fragment (p^{52}), pictured here, has confirmed a much earlier date. P^{52} is the oldest fragment of a manuscript from the New Testament yet discovered and has been dated to around AD 135. The fragment is from a codex-style manuscript (a book, rather than a scroll), with John 18:31–33 written on one side and John 18:37–38 on the other.



John’s Gospel

Reading John Today

- With its elegant simplicity and deep spiritual insight, John’s Gospel is perhaps the most loved of the four Gospels. It is also the most widely distributed, sometimes being printed as an evangelistic “tract” to lead people to Christ. The author would surely be pleased with such a publication, fitting as it does his narrative purpose (John 20:31).
- John’s Gospel is fundamentally a call to decision. Like the characters in the story—Nicodemus, the Samaritan woman, Peter, and others—each reader encounters the claims of Jesus and must respond with acceptance or rejection.

John’s Gospel

Reading John Today

- Nor is there any middle ground in this decision. John draws a stark contrast between those who believe in Jesus and those who reject him, the children of God and the children of Satan, those in the light and those in darkness.
- Jesus preaches an exclusive gospel: the Son is the only way to the Father. All others stand condemned. Forged in the heat of competing religious claims, the Gospel is both a call for faith leading to life, and a warning against disbelief leading to death.
- To be sure, this is an unpopular message in today’s society, in which claims to absolute truth are dismissed as naive and relativism is the order of the day. But it is a message the Fourth Evangelist passionately believed the world needed to hear.